

KEY FIGURE

RAMESSES II

1279–1213 BCE

One of the longest-reigning Egyptian pharaohs, Ramesses II led numerous military campaigns, taking armies into Syria to the east, Libya to the west, and Nubia in the far south. His main rival was the Hittite emperor, Mutawallis. The climax of his second Syrian campaign was the Battle of Kadesh in 1275 BCE, a clash with the Hittites that involved large chariot forces on both sides. Ramesses survived a devastating charge by the Hittite chariots to emerge victorious.



▲ The head from a colossal statue of Ramesses II at the Temple of Abu Simbel, in southern Egypt.

► TUTANKHAMEN

The Egyptian pharaoh Tutankhamen (reigned 1332–1322 BCE) is depicted shooting volleys of arrows at his fleeing enemies. In reality, the king was a boy who would not have led his troops in battle.

▼ AN EGYPTIAN SPEAR

The thrusting spear was the main weapon of Egyptian infantrymen, particularly under the Old Kingdom (2686–2181 BCE). Like many ancient armies, the Egyptians fought in phalanxes, which opponents found difficult to penetrate.



KEY DEVELOPMENT

THE FIRST WARRIORS

The birth of advanced civilizations in the Near East, around 3000 BCE, heralded the emergence of organized military forces. Over the next 3,000 years, a series of technical developments led to advances in weaponry, which in turn shaped the development of military tactics.

While it is likely that there was conflict of some sort between groups of hunters before agriculture began, a permanent warrior class only arose with the first farming communities, which needed to protect their surpluses. The earliest agricultural societies built defences (such as the walls of Jericho, in around 8000 BCE) and adapted stone hunting weapons for use in battle, leading to the invention of weapons such as the mace. It was not

until the rise of the city-states of Sumeria, however, in the late 4th millennium BCE, that true organized armies began to appear.

THE RACE FOR COPPER

The discovery of copper-refining methods around 4500 BCE led to the manufacture of the first metallic weapons, and may also have set off competition between city-states for access to the copper mines of Anatolia. These two factors contributed to the endemic state of war between Sumerian city-states, such as Uruk, Ur, and Kish, during the 3rd and 4th millennia BCE. Sumerian soldiers fought largely on foot, armed with long spears and

